

Case Study: UPI / Online Payment Fraud

UPI (Unified Payments Interface) fraud is a rapidly growing cybercrime in which attackers deceive users into transferring money or revealing confidential banking details. With the increasing use of digital payment apps, such scams have become more frequent and sophisticated.

A typical UPI fraud follows a clear pattern. First, the fraudster contacts the victim through a phone call, SMS, or messaging platform, pretending to be a bank official, delivery agent, or customer support executive. Next, they create a sense of urgency or offer an attractive benefit such as a refund, cashback, or prize. Then, the victim is instructed to click on a fraudulent link or approve a "collect request" sent to their UPI application. In some cases, the attacker may ask for sensitive details like an OTP or UPI PIN under false pretenses. Once the victim follows these instructions, the money is instantly transferred to the fraudster's account.

Such scams commonly target college students, elderly individuals, and people who are less aware of digital payment security practices. Small business owners and online sellers are also vulnerable.

The consequences include financial loss, emotional stress, and reduced trust in online payment systems. Since transactions are instant, recovering lost money can be difficult. This highlights the importance of awareness, verifying payment requests, and never sharing confidential information like OTPs or UPI PINs.